



Agile Project Manager Top Tips

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Principles – Top Tips

- Treat non-adherence to the principles as a risk
 - Breaking any of the principles will be a significant risk to the success of the agile process and the success of the project
- Discuss the Principles openly with the project team at the start of the project and ensure everyone buys into them, Demonstrate Control is not just a PM issue
- Make the Principles visible to all
- During an Increment Review consider how the Principles have been applied and decide if any behaviours need to be changed for the next increment

Roles – Top Tips

- Ensure SDT know their boundaries and then let them get on with doing their job
- Build a good relationship with the team, so you are confident they will escalate to you when necessary
- Clarify roles and responsibilities from the start and ensure the person taking that role is happy with what is expected of them
- Business Ambassador role and their on-going commitment is critical for successful Agile projects and check that the business has confidence in the person taking this role
- Build a good relationship with the Business Sponsor. Having a high level champion increases likelihood of success
- Ideally there should be a single Business Sponsor and single Business Visionary
- If there is a need for multiple sponsors make sure the Project Manager has agreed escalation path and direct contact with an empowered decision maker.
- Multiple business Visionaries can cause problems with lack of clarity, power and passion that is more evident when one person takes on this role. This is often driven by politics of the organisation. The steering group needs to ensure all views are represented and the solution meets the needs of the organisation.
- On a small project, roles will be combined, for example Business Analyst and Team Leader because they are both focused on the feasibility, cohesion and acceptability of the solution

- PM and Team Leader role is often the same person, unless PM is managing multiple teams. Always be aware of what role you are in at a point in time as the behaviours are different
- On a large multi-team project there might be a need for a Technical Coordination Team
- Keep team size small, (ideally team will be 7 +/-2), this encourages face-to-face, less-formal communication

Preparing For Success – Top Tips

- Instrumental Success Factors need constant monitoring - where they can't be met they represent key risks to the project
- Empowerment is two-way
 - Teams using this process first time may need coaxing to make their own decisions
 - The daily stand up will show highlight risks
- Acceptance of philosophy may be difficult in organisations using agile for first time
 - Consider piloting the philosophy (perhaps on a less critical initiative) to help to win acceptance
- If co-location is not possible, try to have an area where everyone can come together from time to time to provide focus for the project
- Larger teams can be subdivided into smaller teams if the requirements can be split accordingly
 - Use cross-team stand ups (representatives from each team getting together) to maintain communication.
- Never compromise on Business time

Agile Project Management – Top Tips

- Trust the team and build an environment of honesty, openness and no-blame
- A co-located team is the ideal. Communication becomes much easier
 - If total co-location is impossible, plan for how communication will be done effectively. It doesn't just happen by itself
- Protect the team from unnecessary external impacts.
- Ensure the team have the right equipment and environment to do the job
 - Be the bridge between the team and other stakeholders but encourage communication between them
- Take responsibility for keeping stakeholders informed. Be open and honest with them. Constant communication avoids problems
- Tread the fine line of steering the project without interfering. The team still looks to PM for guidance but doesn't want to be directed.

Lifecycle – Top Tips

- The life-cycle is very configurable for different projects and products
 - Sequential for Pre-project, Feasibility and Foundations
 - Typically many iterations of Evolutionary Development
 - Typically many separate Deployments
 - Post project sequential with the last Deployment.
 - This configurability allows the project manager significant opportunity to deliver business value early and to demonstrate progress
- Keep the phases of the life cycle visible to the Solution Development Team during the project
- Plan incrementally
- Typically, plan for Feasibility and Foundations phases is shorter than would be the case for a more traditional project
- Allow for just enough design up front (EDUF)

Products – Top Tips

- Think carefully about the intended value of every product, not all projects need every product
- You do not always need formal documents
- They should be as brief and focussed as possible
- Don't create a document just to tick a box
- Don't use standard templates blindly, tailor them to suit the project

Iterative Development – Top Tips

- If the team can demonstrate they are in control, and are following the process, the Agile PM should not need to interfere or try to direct them
 - Team empowerment is key to successful agile projects, all the necessary skills and knowledge are within the team
- Manage iterative development by exception
 - Ensure the Team are confident and comfortable to raise issues to you for resolution
- Monitor the business involvement during iterative development
 - This is easier if amount of expected business involvement is made clear and explicit in the early stages. The PM can quickly see if the amount of time being given is as expected or less than expected

Prioritizing –Top Tips

- Agree what the priorities mean early in the project
 - A must Have means that the product won't work without it or is unsafe – non negotiable
 - If a workaround can be put in place then it is not a Must Have
 - Look for defined boundaries between a Should and a Could
- Set the balance of priorities to the risk profile of the project.
 - Where there is higher risk of unknowns, like for example, new technology or a newly formed team, then the project may decide to use a lower percentage of Must Haves
- Use all the priorities
- Challenge Must Haves
- Control the percentage of Must Haves
 - The target of no more than 60% is to assure predictability.
 - As the percentage of Must Haves increases above 60%, predictability of the project decreases and risk of failure increases unless:
 - some of the estimates are known to be true based on past experience
 - the approach is tried and tested
 - the team is well established with a proven track record
 - the environment is well understood and relatively stable
- Agree most of the priorities before work is started in Foundations
- Allow different priorities for acceptance criteria of a requirement
 - A query response Should be less than 2 seconds but Must respond within 4 seconds
- Any new requirements or unexpected work for an existing requirement needs to be evaluated against how critical it is to the existing work using MoSCoW. Care should be taken not to increase the percentage of Must Haves beyond the agreed project level
- At a minimum review priorities at the end of each Timebox
- Re-prioritise all requirements that have not been met at the end of a Project Increment in the light of the needs of the next increment. They are not automatically carried over
- Prioritise everything – It helps the concept become deeply ingrained in the team's approach

Structured Timeboxes –Top Tips

- Commit to Timeboxing
 - Encourage the Team to finish on time by prioritising what is done, rather than letting a Timebox 'expand'
- Check Timebox progress by daily 'stand-up' meetings
 - Enable team to react to any problems immediately
- Build an environment of trust and 'no blame'
 - The only way to ensure team are open about progress
- Ensure the Timebox Kick-off involves the right people.
- Ensure acceptance criteria for successful Timebox completion are as clear as possible at Kickoff, and clarified further during Investigation.
- Ensure that key risks which may affect a Timebox are identified at Kick-off, and monitored during the Timebox.
- Ensure that the 'Close-out' also performs a review (a Retrospective) of learning points to feed into future Timeboxes.

Agile Control –Top Tips

- Listen to your team and act on their suggestions and concerns
- Let the team get on with it, but act on issues as soon as possible
 - Small issues will soon grow and affect the project
- Maintain communication
 - Speak to key people every day, if possible, and attend the team's daily stand ups
- Progress is measured on completion of features, not completion of tasks

Risk – Top Tips

- Use Project Approach Questionnaire to identify risks to the DSDM process
- Ensure the PAQ is completed collaboratively as a minimum with the Business Visionary and the Technical Coordinator
- Ensure the answers to the PAQ are realistic and not overly optimistic or pessimistic
- Monitor behaviours to ensure adherence to Principles – Breaking any Principle poses significant risk to success of the project
- Ensure whole team are aware of key risks – make them visible – In Agile, risks are not just a PMs concern
- At Timebox Kick Off, highlight risks relevant to this Timebox – Consider handing ownership of these Timebox risks to Team Leader
- Encourage Solution Development Teams to consider risks at planning and review sessions
- At end of Timebox, consider taking ownership of new and outstanding risks back to the project level
- At the end of a Timebox, possibly during the Close-Out session, consider taking ownership of new and outstanding risks back to the project-level roles

Estimating –Top Tips

- Estimating small pieces of work provides more accuracy
- Allow people doing the work to do the estimates
- It is acceptable to challenge an estimate by challenging the assumption upon which it is based. It is not acceptable to challenge it with the sole purpose of forcing more work to be done
- Teams should get estimates from several people
- Present early estimates as a range
- Re- estimation happens throughout
 - Use MoSCoW to stay on track
- Do not allow desire to protect initial estimates prevent change occurring

Measurement –Top Tips

- If you are not measuring it, you cannot control it
- Keep it simple
 - Use fewest and simplest measures that answer your questions
- Be specific – define measures accurately
- Evaluate the Return on Investment of any given measure
 - Is it worth collecting the data?
- Automate collection of measures as much as possible
- Measure outcomes, not outputs
- Combine, compare and interpret measures to answer defined questions

- Be aware of the fact that measures drive behaviours, so understand the likely effect
- Change measures as required during a project

Agile Planning – Top Tips

- Always involve the Solution Development Team and other interested stakeholders in Plans
 - This way they feel ownership and the plans are more likely to be correct
- Always expect the unexpected and plan in contingency
 - Agile projects fix time, so contingency is in balancing ‘Must Have’, ‘Should Have’ and ‘Could Have’ items in Development Timeboxes
- A plan is a guide - it is always subject to change
 - Expect change and don’t be scared to update plans
- Always make plans visible to whole team and to stakeholders
- Always be transparent on progress against plan
- Past experience is a good guide in estimating and planning new projects. Collecting previous project statistics helps
- Experience on THE CURRENT PROJECT should be used to refine plans
 - The more you know, the better you can plan
- Timebox planning is not the responsibility of the PM, it is owned by the Solution Development Team

Quality – Top Tips

- Compromising quality is never acceptable as in the long term it does not save time
- It is very hard to include quality retrospectively
 - Planning quality in from the start avoids surprises later
 - Quality is built-in, not bolted on
- Constant discussion with and feedback from all stakeholders helps improve quality
- Quality is often variable from project by project but once the level is decided upon it is fixed for that project

Testing – Top Tips

- Should be integrated, not an afterthought
- Early testing reduces risk
- Encourage Solution Developers to demonstrate their work early
- Encourage Business Ambassadors to get involved in testing as early as possible
- Testing should be completed in the Development Timebox

- Early testing creates feedback for converging on the accurate solution. This feedback is a positive aspect of Agile Development and must not be counted as 'bugs'
- Testing is largely controlled and implemented by the development teams(s), there will be activities that will almost certainly require intervention from the Project Manager, e.g. integration across teams and scheduling facilitated workshops

Requirements and User Stories – Top Tips

- Ensure requirements come from the right people. The Business Visionary (owner of the process) provides the high level requirements, the Business Ambassador(s) and Business Advisor(s) (the end users of the solution) provide the detail
- All prioritisation of requirements is with respect to the project objectives
- Beware of too much detail too early, typically less than 10 Requirements by the end of feasibility and less than one hundred by the end of Foundations. Any more and this introduces a risk to the effective use of AgilePM
- Use workshops for agreeing requirements
- Ensure there is an agreed requirements baseline by the end of Foundations – without this it is impossible to control scope
- New requirements may need to be incorporated into the solution or the PRL throughout, all part of iterative development. Changes to the baseline (the breadth) need to be managed more formally than expansion of details (the depth).
- The PRL can also be used to capture progress. Some PRL templates allow this to be used as a Burn Down chart – a graph showing the expected rate of requirements completion to achieve the deadline. This has an advantage of making slippage visible as soon as it happens.

Tailoring – Top Tips

- PAQ should be completed with the Business Visionary, Technical Coordinator and Project Manager as an absolute minimum
- Realism rather than optimism or pessimism should be used to complete the PAQ
- Keep an eye on the PAQ throughout the project. If it becomes apparent that some of the statements are false, immediate action should be taken
- The PAQ should be used to drive appropriate tailoring of the approach which should be documented in the Management Approach Definition
- Consider how to integrate with other project management methods such as PRINCE2 and other development methods such as Scrum

